to our BSF or ITBP) but regular PLA troops in full combat gear. They had come fully kitted out with riot shields, batons, barbed-wire studded clubs and pyrotechnics. In the face of this sudden wave of PLA troops, our jawans were outnumbered and though they resisted bravely, were slowly pushed back to the West of Finger 4. This whole activity was once again in gross violation of all laid-down protocols and agreements on confidence-building measures. The PLA occupied the lower reaches of Finger 4, effectively precluding any more patrolling on our part to its East. To sustain themselves and for administrative purposes, the PLA constructed some shelters at various points along the North Bank of the Pangong Tso, including an outline map of China in the vicinity of Finger 6, large enough to be seen by air.

This obviously created a stir in the politico-military establishment. As mentioned earlier, the NSA had spoken to his counterpart earlier in the month over the Doklam issue. In that interaction, they had reiterated the need to maintain peace and tranquillity, and adherence to protocols, including non-use of force or weapons. The PLA's actions were a total departure from what had been discussed. Either the PLA was acting in isolation, which is hard to believe, given the autocratic nature of their systems, or the Chinese were insincere in their talks. We knew that there was a greater than normal presence of troops in the general area of Sirijap, the 'capability'; but were unable to gauge the true 'intention' in a timely manner, due to a lack of adequate Intelligence, Surveillance and Reconnaissance (ISR) capability at the tactical level. Were we surprised at the strategic level? The answer is a resounding No. Did we get surprised at the ground level? Yes, but that is something which is bound to happen with whoever seizes the initiative—the first-mover advantage, like playing with the white pieces in a game of chess.

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